the two rival camps were sent to the Imperial Court in Beijing in 1734. Peace was achieved and the country was unified, but, as Aris points out, 'the submission to Chinese mediation entailed a theoretical loss of sovereignty'. At the same time, however, 'it led to the establishment of formal diplomatic relations with Tibet that helped to guarantee the fact of Bhutanese independence'.[16]

And it was not China but Britain that came to play an important role in the subsequent history of Bhutan. It began in the 1770s with the Bhutanese seizing control of the principality of Cooch Behar (now Koch Bihar) in the plains below the Himalayas. To rid the state of the invaders, the ruler of Cooch Behar appealed for help from the British East India Company. About 600 Bhutanese soldiers were killed in the first encounter on 22 December 1772 alone as British forces ousted them from the Cooch Behar fort.[17] Britain now replaced Tibet as the major external threat to Bhutan.

Boundary disputes continued to affect relations between the British and the Bhutanese. The British gained control over Assam after a war with the Myanmar kingdom in 1824–6, and proceeded to occupy the remaining Bhutanese-controlled areas in the plains. Several military encounters between British and Bhutanese forces came in the wake of colonial expansion into the Brahmaputra Valley. Bhutanese troops raided Cooch Behar and Sikkim in 1862, by which time the British Crown had taken over control of India from the East India Company. The British counterattacked, and, despite some battlefield victories for the Bhutanese, the conflicts ended with the Treaty of Sinchula, which was signed on 11 November 1865. Bhutan had to give up all claims to the Assam Duars, or foothills, in return for a subsidy of Rs 50,000. Article I of the Treaty also stated that '[t]here shall henceforth be perpetual peace and friendship between the British Government and the Government of Bhootan'.[18]

The loss of the plains dealt a severe blow to the Bhutanese economy and lead to civil strife within what remained of the country. While reincarnations of the shabdrung continued to be the spiritual head of Bhutan, the provinces were ruled by more worldly administrators who bore the title '*penlop*' or '*pönlop*'. The penlop of Tongsa was considered pro-British, while his counterpart in Paro was pro-Tibetan. Towards the end of the nineteenth century, Ugyen Wangchuk, the Tongsa penlop, emerged as